Brooder



Category: **Animal Husbandry & Dairy** Type: **Full SOP** Priority: **High** 1 labs

Covers these lab items: Reflectors/ Hovers

What it is used for

A poultry brooder, using a reflector, hover, or other approved heat source, provides young chicks with a suitable warm area during early growth. Set up the brooder to create a safe temperature gradient and monitor chick behaviour to prevent chilling, overheating, crowding, and fire.

Main parts

- Reflector, hover, or heating unit
- Heating element or approved heat source
- Height adjustment or suspension supports
- Temperature gauge or thermometer
- Protective guard and chick enclosure
- Power supply or fuel connection, depending on model

Before you start

1. Confirm the chick age, number, breed, and recommended brooding temperature from the husbandry plan or veterinary guidance.
2. Inspect the heater, reflector, supports, guards, cables, fuel connections, and controls for damage.
3. Clean and dry the brooding area and provide suitable bedding, water, and feed.
4. Position the heat source securely above the designated area and maintain the specified clearance from bedding and combustible materials.
5. Check ventilation and ensure that chicks cannot touch the hot element or electrical parts.
6. Use a reliable thermometer at chick level and verify that backup heat and emergency arrangements are available.

How to use

1. Install the brooder according to the manufacturer's instructions and secure all supports before energising it.
2. Start the heat source in advance of chick arrival so the floor and brooding area reach the required temperature.
3. Measure temperature at chick level at several positions to confirm an even gradient.
4. Adjust heater height or output according to the equipment design and the recommended temperature range.
5. Introduce chicks gently and observe whether they spread evenly, gather under the heat, or move away from it.

6. Check chick activity, feeding, drinking, and signs of panting, huddling, or distress at regular intervals.
7. Adjust heat and ventilation gradually in response to measured temperature and chick behaviour.
8. Keep bedding dry and remove wet or heavily soiled patches promptly.
9. If the heater fails, temperature becomes unsafe, or smoke or unusual odour appears, activate the emergency plan and provide safe backup heat.
10. During routine checks, confirm that guards, supports, and power or fuel connections remain secure.
11. Reduce or remove supplementary heat gradually according to chick age, feather development, and husbandry guidance.
12. Clean the area and inspect the brooder after the flock has been moved.

⚠ Safety

- Only trained personnel should install or adjust the brooder heat source.
- Keep heat sources away from bedding, dust, curtains, and other combustible materials.
- Never leave an unstable or unguarded heater where chicks can contact it.
- For fuel-burning brooders, provide required ventilation and inspect for gas leaks and carbon monoxide risks.
- Protect electrical connections from moisture and pecking; isolate power before maintenance.
- Do not make sudden temperature changes that could stress or harm chicks.

Care & storage

- Clean the reflector, guard, and surrounding area after shutdown and cooling.
- Inspect suspension chains, supports, guards, heating elements, and cables regularly.
- Check temperature gauges against a reliable reference at specified intervals.
- Replace damaged components and service fuel or electrical systems according to the manufacturer's instructions.
- Keep the brooder dry, secure, and ready for inspection before each new batch.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Setting the brooder too high or too low without checking chick-level temperature.
- Ignoring chick huddling, panting, or uneven distribution.
- Placing the heater too close to bedding or combustible materials.
- Failing to maintain ventilation or provide backup heat during equipment failure.

Disclaimer: This SOP is prepared from general information available on the internet. For detailed instructions, refer to the manufacturer's original manual / file.